

Cut your losses and get on to the next game.

Cheats

In older versions of *Minesweeper* (before Windows XP), you could stop the clock by keeping the left and right mouse buttons pressed and pressing [Esc]. This doesn't work with Windows XP's version of *Minesweeper*, but you can always download the Windows 98 version and overwrite winmine.exe in the C:\Windows\System32\ folder.

Another interesting cheat is to start *Minesweeper*, then type [X] + [Y] + [Z] + [Z] + [Y] + [Shift] + [Enter] + [Enter] (that's xzyzz + Shift + Enter twice) on your keyboard. This will display a single pixel on the top left of your desktop that glows white when you hover an empty space and black when you hover over a mine—this obviously only works to your advantage when you have a black desktop background, so that you can see the pixel glow white when you are over a square that doesn't contain a mine. It also will not help your time much, especially if you depend on this pixel to solve your game. However, this can help a lot when you're stuck with an unsolvable pattern (where guesswork is needed).

Alternatives

There are many clones for *Minesweeper*, including those that use hexagons instead of squares, making the sweeping more complicated. There is also the official *Minesweeper Clone*, which has an inbuilt recording facility and is cheat-proof. If you find yourself getting good enough to challenge the masters of *Minesweeper*, you will need *Minesweeper Clone*. Records are only acknowledged if you send in a recording of it, and *Minesweeper Clone* will let you play back the records of the masters, in case you want to see how they play. Just visit www.planet-minesweeper.com to delve into the wonderful world of minesweeping.

We should mention that, currently, the world records for the three levels are:

Beginner	:	1 second
Intermediate	:	10 seconds
Expert	:	38 Seconds

You can only get into the hall of fame if your combined time (Beginner + Intermediate + Expert) is 99 seconds or less! Happy sweeping!

SPIDER SOLITAIRE

The aim of this game is to empty out 10 stacks of cards by building each suit from King to Ace. It involves two decks of cards, and you can choose between just a single suit (easy) to all four suits (highest difficulty).

It's All In The Suit

If you want to have any kind of success in *Spider Solitaire*, always try to build according to suit. This is the most basic point of the game, because only when you have King through Ace of the same suit (all 13 cards) does it get taken off the playing board. Also, if you have, say, Jack of Clubs through Six of Clubs, you can move that whole build of cards to another slot, together. So building in-suit allows you to reveal more of the covered cards.

Exposé

This holds true for any form of *Solitaire*: try your best to expose the covered cards. The only way you can win at this game is if you focus more on opening all the covered cards rather than building a single sequence and losing focus on the rest. Besides, covered cards are of no use to anyone, so the faster you uncover them the better your chances of building multiple sequences.

Kings High

Kings are your friends, unless there are no Queens to be found, that is. Focus on building on top of higher-ranked cards. An Ace on a covered pile is just useless unless there's a two around; a Jack, on the other hand, is a nice option for a Ten of any suit. So make sure to try and keep all playable cards as high as possible.

Don't Mix

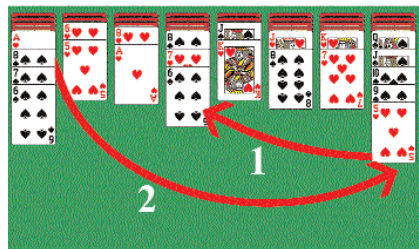
Although in *Spider Solitaire* you are allowed to place, say, a Six of any suit on a Seven of any other suit. This is just going to get you stuck. Obviously, sometimes you might want to mix and match to try and open out more covered cards in the hope that you get the cards that you're looking for; but as far as possible, don't ruin a built sequence by adding a card of another suit. Whenever possible, always mix suits in sequences that already have mixed cards. Later you can always un-mix them when you have a few free spaces on the board.

Dealing Is Death

Don't just deal the next hand in the hope that you will get some good cards. It's better to try and keep playing without dealing. The longer you play and the more options you try, the better your chances of opening out covered cards. Dealing the next hand is like the "Get out of jail free" card in *Monopoly*—only to be used in emergencies, or when there's no other choice.

Mixed Suits

Often, you find yourself with, say, King through Nine of Hearts, then Eight of Spades, and then Seven through Ace



1: If you have to mix suits, add to an already mixed pile. 2: This helps you build better

of Hearts again. In such a case, keep an eye out for the first opportunity where an Eight of Hearts is available, and any other Nine is free. Let's say you have the Eight of hearts open, quickly move the Seven through Ace of Hearts on to the Eight of Hearts, then the Eight of spades on to any available Nine, and then move the Eight through Ace of hearts back on to the original pile to complete the sequence. This holds true when any sequence is broken up by one card from a different suit.

Don't Touch The King

A very common mistake all novice *Spider Solitaire* players make is to move a King to the first available empty space. Unless you can get that whole sequence (King to Ace) in three moves or less, you're asking for trouble. Empty spaces on the board (created after all the covered cards in that pile have been opened and moved) are what will help you win the game. Any card from Queen through Ace, when put in an empty space, can be moved out again, but a King in an empty space can only be moved off the board—when the entire sequence of King to Ace of that suit is completed. So next time a King is on top of a pile and a space opens out, don't just pop it into the empty slot hoping to be able to build from there.

Think Ahead

Spider Solitaire, like any thinking game, requires some planning. You should always be thinking at least three moves ahead for even a single suit (easy) game. Good players think as much as 10 moves ahead when playing with all four suits (highest difficulty). You will have to learn to visualise your moves before you make them. So when you're thinking of moving a card, look at the board in your mind and see what that move will mean for the rest of the game—will you be able to continue? Will moving this card really help? Also, it's most important to see all your available moves before making any move, even the very first one. Sometimes games are lost just because the first move was wrong. Also never be shy to use the [Ctrl] + [Z] (undo) option that's available, but remember that it is only available till the last hand was dealt.